The Āb-i-istāda

In a few marches, they reached Āb-i-istāda—a delightfully large water body picturesque to view.

Babur has sumptuously described the scene:[*]

> The level lands on its further side could not be seen at all; its water seemed to join the sky; the higher land and the mountains of that further side looked to hang between Heaven and Earth, as in a mirage.

The water was said to have come from the spring-rain floods of the Kattawāz-plain, the Zurmut Valley, and the Qarā-bāgh meadow of the Ghaznī-torrent, floods of the spring-rains, and the over-plus of the summer-rise of streams.

When they were two miles from the Āb-i-istāda, they saw an interesting thing. They kept on seeing rose-like figures rising and vanishing at the horizon above water repeatedly. When they reached closer, they saw large flocks of flamingos—thousands of them. When the birds flapped their wings in flight, sometimes red feathers appeared and sometimes not. They saw many eggs on the shore.

Two Afghāns came to collect the eggs. They saw Babur’s troop. They swam away half a mile out of fear. They wanted to go unnoticed, but they couldn’t escape Babur’s eyes. He brought them back.

Following these events, Babur dismounted at the inundation coming down to the Āb-i-istāda from the plain of Kattawāz. Each time Babur had gone by it in the past, the channel had been dry, but this time it was full of water. Perhaps no ford could be found due to the spring rains. The channel was deep but not very broad. They couldn’t manage to go beyond without crossing it. The horses and camels were made to swim in it and the baggage was towed over with ropes. After getting across, they went on through Old Nānī and Sar-i-dih to Ghaznī. For a few days, Jahāngīr Mīrzā hosted them, offered food and offered the due tribute.

Return to Kābul

Unfortunately, the floods had been massive in AD 1505. They could not find any crossing over the water of Logar. Hence, they had to go straight on to Kamarī, through the Sajāwand-pass. At Kamarī, Babur managed to get a boat. It was one fashioned in a pool and brought and set on the Logar water, in front of Kamarī in which Babur put all his people.